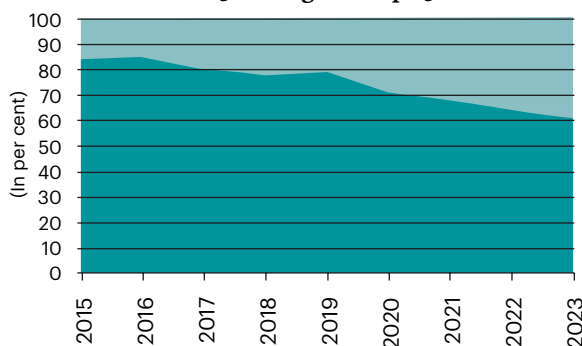


Course Correction

The share of engineers, however, has steadily declined since 2015 among the Top 25 B-schools



■ Engineers ■ Non-engineers

Source BT-MDRA survey



“A good leader comes in so many shapes and sizes that the leader at the top could come from any background”

VARUN NAGARAJ
DEAN, S.P. JAIN INSTITUTE OF
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sion Test, the entrance test for MBA colleges in India), which makes it easier for engineers to crack the exam and pick higher-ranked colleges.

SPJIMR's Nagaraj says they are consciously trying to build candidate diversity at the admission stage, within the parameters of a transparent process. Indeed, the share of engineers has steadily declined since 2015 among the Top 25 schools, shows BT-MDRA data. “But it's nothing compared to what they have in the US, not close at all,” says Nagaraj, adding that it could possibly improve as more students graduate from liberal arts schools such as Krea University and Ashoka University. MBA Crystal Ball's Gupta says the Indian two-year programme is less valuable abroad because of this

class homogeneity of educational background, nationality and gender. “If there is no dissent, individual thinking within the group doesn't get pushed up.”

This diversity, and the opening up of a global career path, are among the biggest allures for students to pursue an international MBA even though it doesn't come cheap. As many as 26,000 Indian students went to the US for business and management programmes in the 2021-22 academic year, as per data from US State Department-funded initiative ‘Open Doors 2022’. One may have to shell out ₹1-1.5 crore for an MBA in the US or Europe, depending on the school and course duration. An IIM MBA, on the other hand, costs around ₹20-25 lakh, while other GMAT-based MBAs in India like the ones offered by ISB in Hyderabad and Mohali could cost ₹30-40 lakh. “Purely from an immediate financial burden perspective, the Indian MBA might have an edge over global MBAs. But the trajectory you can achieve with an international MBA is very rare to achieve with an Indian MBA,” says Gupta.

IIML's Jakhar agrees that finding positions abroad becomes easier when you have a network of international peers. But all top global consulting firms also recruit from the IIMs, apart from a recent interest from Middle-Eastern firms as well, he adds. If one does well, one can move internally from an India office to, say, a New York office of one of the top consulting firms even without an international credential, adds Nagaraj. “The key thing is, MNCs place Indian MBAs at the level they would hire US undergrads because they treat the Indian MBA as a finishing school added on to the three-four-year degree.”

INTELLECTUAL CAPITAL

Another crucial reason why Indian institutes are not world-class yet is the lack of investment in faculty, say experts. Mumbai-based MBA consultant Jatin Bhandari's firm PythaGURUS Education coaches more than 100 students every year to get into top B-schools in India and abroad. An alumnus of Darden School of Business, University of Virginia, he speaks of how General Electric's then CEO Jeff Immelt showed up in Darden's class one day to take a 45-minute session on why the company sold NBCUniversal to Comcast. “How many gods of Wall Street will show up at your class and teach you here?” He says Indian schools don't have the kind of money to retain, say, a Dipak Jain. The Indian-origin former dean of INSEAD and Kellogg School of Management is now the Co-President and Global Advisor of China